



“They all go  
completely  
**naked, even  
the women ...**”

CHRISTOPHER COLUMBUS ON THE TAÍNO WOMEN OF  
SAN SALVADOR, 1492

## THE CRIMES OF COLUMBUS

At the end of the 15th century, Ferdinand and Isabella of Spain (see pp. 94–95) commissioned explorer Christopher Columbus to sail west, in search of a new trade route to Asia. During his voyage, in 1492, Columbus landed in the Caribbean, laying the foundations for subsequent European exploration and colonization of the New World. Columbus's reports home falsely depicted the women he met on his travels—who, in truth, were not fully naked—as both promiscuous and naive; according to Columbus, this made them the perfect candidates to be Christianized and turned into servants. Columbus and his men treated the native women as little more than sexual objects. Accounts by his crew claimed that they were so overcome by desire for the women that they took them against their will, and also contained evidence that girls as young as nine or ten were sold into sexual slavery. The print (left) also reflects the exaggerated fantasies of the colonists; it depicts the conquistador Hernán Cortés (see pp. 98–99) receiving a woman from the Tabasco Indians (in what is now Mexico).